

they had little chance of going on a real hunt in the nearby fields and forests. For these city dwellers, a show in the arena was their equivalent of "virtual reality," where the countryside appeared before their eyes, complete with wild animals, scenery, trees ... and hunters.

Animals were transported to Rome from all over the empire. Africa supplied lions, leopards, monkeys, crocodiles, hippos, rhinos, and ostriches. Elephants traveled from Africa and Asia, and wild boars came from the forests of northern Europe. At the Colosseum, animals were kept in rooms and cages under the floor of the arena. Elevators

raised them to the surface where they appeared, as if by magic, through trapdoors.

Thrown to the beasts

The Romans learned many things from their friends and enemies—and not all of them were pleasant! For example, they got the idea of throwing criminals to wild beasts from the Carthaginians of North Africa, who used elephants to squash army deserters to death.

In Roman hands, this method of execution became a gory spectacle. Men and women who had committed serious crimes were tied to wooden posts in the arena, where lions,

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